much to his embarrassment, nine years later, in the dressing room at the Oval at the end of my final Test. I naturally gave him grief, but had to admit I had no idea of what he had done. The catch was a sitter; he might have had to dive for it, but when it slipped, he just scooped it off the ground. It was cheeky, but showed strength of mind, and confidence beyond his years. He was only sixteen, remember. A more seasoned pro would have probably obeyed convention, said, 'I dropped that,' and thrown it in, but Rooty showed the sort of spikiness I quickly recognized in Jimmy Anderson.

He was a winner.

Our paths crossed occasionally before he was picked for his first senior tour, in India in 2012. He was obviously very comfortable in an elite environment. He wasn't a gym junkie, had a little bit of puppy fat, which he has yet to lose, but he looked like he belonged.

International cricket didn't faze him. He wasn't scared by the challenge. He waited patiently for his chance and looked ready to play when we picked him for the final Test at Nagpur. Batting at six, as opposed to his normal position as opener, his 73 in our first-innings 330 made him joint top-scorer with Kevin Pietersen.

First tours are usually dangerous affairs, because they represent a step into the unknown, but the way Rooty walked to the middle, a massive smile shining out from under the England cap that had been presented by Paul Collingwood, was reassuring. The bloke could play spin, having perfected his technique with the Lions in Bangladesh and Sri Lanka, and he relaxed into the moment. He's now at the stage of his career where perspective is possible. To me, he is the most complete English batsman I've seen. More intriguingly, I wonder if, in different circumstances, he could have made KP an even better player.

Rooty has proved it is possible to average more than 50 in both Test and one-day cricket. His consistency of performance is phenomenal. The last time I saw his limited-over stats he was averaging 58 over the past four years, with a strike rate in excess of 90. He is almost redefining the boundaries of the modern game, in tandem with Jos Buttler.

Kevin set the same pioneering standard in terms of power and improvisation but had his moments when his form dipped slightly. Rooty can't match the magical nature of some of his innings but has huge impact on a regular basis. I suspect KP would have responded to the metronomic